

SOP-NOISE-1800: Hearing Conservation Program

Document owner: Occupational Health Department **Effective date:** 2024-02-10 **Review cycle:** 36 months

Section 1. Purpose and Scope

Governs noise monitoring, hearing protection, and audiometric testing for employees exposed to occupational noise.

Section 2. Monitoring and Action Level

Clause 2.1 — Any work area with an 8-hour time-weighted average noise exposure at or above 85 dBA is enrolled in the Hearing Conservation Program; areas are re-surveyed every 24 months or after any process change affecting noise generation.

Section 3. Hearing Protection

Clause 3.1 — Hearing protection is mandatory in any area posted as a Hearing Protection Zone; dual protection (plugs and muffs) is required where measured exposure exceeds 100 dBA.

Clause 3.2 — Hearing protector selection shall achieve an effective attenuated exposure below 85 dBA using the manufacturer's Noise Reduction Rating derated per Occupational Health Department guidance, not the labeled NRR taken at face value.

Section 4. Audiometric Testing

Clause 4.1 — Baseline audiometric testing is required within 6 months of enrollment in the program, with annual re-testing thereafter.

Clause 4.2 — A standard threshold shift (average 10 dB or more shift at 2000/3000/4000 Hz in either ear compared to baseline) triggers referral to Occupational Health for evaluation and re-fitting of hearing protection, and is recorded regardless of whether the employee reports symptoms.

Section 5. Records

Clause 5.1 — Noise survey data and audiometric test results are filed to the Occupational Health File and retained for the duration of employment plus 30 years, per recordkeeping requirements for hearing conservation data.